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Spread of Christianity



Learning Outcomes

The learner:

- analyses the relationship between the decline of the Roman empire and the spread of Christianity.
- studies the impact of crusades on the social, economic and cultural conditions in medieval Europe.
- analyses the influence of the Church on the life of the people in Europe.

Warm Up!

Critical Thinking



- What role did Emperor Constantine play in the establishment of Christianity in medieval Europe?
- What is the importance of St Peter's Basilica?
- Who is the spiritual head of the Christians throughout the world?

C-2.2

MEDIEVAL PERIOD IN EUROPE

The Medieval Period in Europe was a period of **transition** from the ancient to the modern world. It covered a span of about 900–1,000 years, i.e. from the early 7th century CE to the early 16th century CE. This periodization, however, is not universally accepted because of conflicting interpretations and opinions of **historians and scholars**.

DECLINE OF THE ANCIENT ROMAN EMPIRE

The **mighty Roman empire**, with which India had established important trade relations during the height of its power, began to **disintegrate** by the end of the 5th century CE.

Impact of the Barbarian Invasions

One important reason for the fall of the great empire was the repeated **attacks** by various **Germanic tribes** such as the **Goths**, the **Vandals** and the **Franks**. These raids are sometimes referred to as the **barbarian**

invasions. These invaders penetrated deep into the Roman territory and plundered and ravaged it. Even the magnificent city of Rome was not spared. **These tribes gradually settled down and assumed control of the western part of the Roman empire. The political and economic crises in the Roman empire were other important reasons for its downfall.**

Byzantium: Birth of a New Empire

In 395 CE, the **Roman empire** was divided into two parts—**eastern** and **western**. The eastern part of the Roman empire was known as **Byzantium**. Its capital was Constantinople (present-day Istanbul).

The **Byzantine empire** was also attacked by the 'barbarian tribes', but it proved to be more **resilient** than its western counterpart. It successfully withstood the **onslaughts** and preserved some of the great legacies of the glorious Roman empire.

These **Germanic tribes** had, however, lived for more than a century on the borders of the Roman empire and were familiar with Roman culture. They were **semi-civilized** and brought with them their own **traditions and culture**.

As the unity of Western Europe ended, new forms of government and new centres of power had to be found. One uniting factor was **Christianity and the Roman Church**.



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THE SPREAD OF CHRISTIANITY
The spread of Christianity was one of the most important developments in early medieval Europe. The Germanic tribes that overran Italy, left the Church of Rome unharmed. The Church was allowed to **retain** its spiritual power over all the Christians.

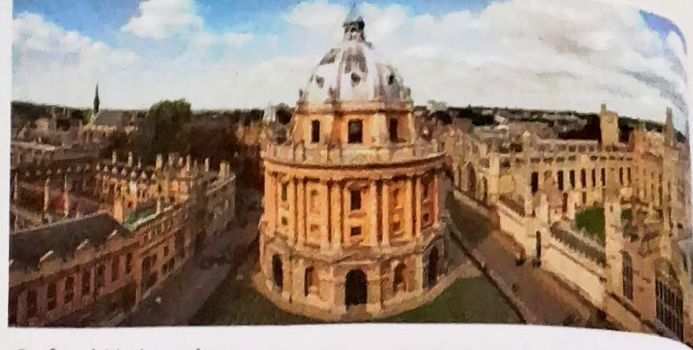
In 400 CE, most people in Europe were non-Christians. Within 500 years, by about 900 CE, most Europeans had been converted to Christianity. In every European state, Christianity had become the **state religion**. The conversion of a king or a feudal lord was usually followed by a **mass conversion** of his subjects. As Christianity spread, the power and wealth of the Church multiplied.

Christian monks, fired by religious fervour, organized themselves into religious **orders**. These orders built great **monasteries** where the monks stayed and pursued their religious missions. The monks also pursued the arts and **learning** in all kinds of subjects. The monasteries became great centres of scholarship, art, literature and religious studies. Majestic churches were built in every town and city. Educational institutions, such as the internationally renowned universities of Cambridge and Oxford, evolved from the monasteries.



Cambridge University

As the wealth and power of the Church increased, it became increasingly **conservative** and **authoritarian**, demanding from every



Oxford University

Christian unqualified obedience, loyalty and total **submission** to its dictates.

Discuss

TP

Communication

In ancient India, students were educated in a guru's ashram. In medieval Europe, monasteries served as centres of education. Discuss the similarities and differences between these two institutions.

C-73

THE CRUSADES

In the 11th century CE, the Muslim Turks invaded the lands of the Christian emperor of Constantinople. Earlier, they had captured Jerusalem, which was a part of the holy land of the Christians. The Pope appealed to Christians to join the Crusades or the **holy war** against the Turks to recover their holy land.

Between the 11th and 13th centuries CE, the Christians led eight military expeditions against the Turks. The Crusades **failed** to achieve their main objective, but they brought about several **significant changes** in medieval Europe:

- In the course of their travels to the holy land, the Crusaders came in contact with the **superior civilizations** and cultures of the **Greeks** and the **Turks**. They **assimilated** the best elements of these cultures and started the process of the revival of Western education and learning, paving the way for the **Renaissance**.
- The Crusaders learned the use of **gunpowder** and guns from the Turks. These two discoveries contributed to the

decline of feudalism.

The armoured knights had outlived their usefulness and their services were no longer required.

- Europe re-established direct trade contacts with other parts of the world. The Crusaders got a taste of the luxurious lifestyle of the East. To meet the demand for luxury items, European

traders began to establish trade links with the East. As trade increased, the economy of Europe flourished.

- Many new towns and cities were established. Traders and manufacturers demanded better conditions of law and order and a better system of law. They paid taxes to the king and helped him to raise a large army. This led to an increase in the

ROUTES TAKEN DURING THE THIRD CRUSADE TP



authority of the king and a decline in the power of the feudal lords.

Did You Know?

The Third Crusade (1189–92 CE) was an attempt by European leaders to reconquer the holy land (Jerusalem) from Saladin (the sultan of Egypt and Syria), who had taken it from the Christians during the First Crusade.

Richard I (Richard the Lionheart) of England and Philip I of France ended their conflict to lead the next Crusade. They were joined by the Holy Roman Emperor, Frederick I (also known as Frederick Barbarossa), who unfortunately died by drowning before reaching the holy land.

Richard I played a vital role by conquering Acre (1191 CE), the walled Muslim city in the Gulf of Haifa. He also finalized a treaty by which Jerusalem remained under Muslim control, but unarmed Christian pilgrims were allowed to visit the city. The failure to regain the holy land led to the call for a fourth Crusade, 6 years later.

Knowledge of India

Takshashila is an ancient university and it is also regarded as an important Buddhist centre of learning. It was founded, according to the Indian epic *Ramayana*, by Bharata, younger brother of Rama. Buddhist literature, especially the *Jatakas*, mentions it as the capital of the kingdom of Gandhara and as a great centre of learning. After partition, the ruins of Takshashila are now in Pakistan.

C-7.1

MONASTERIES AND THEIR IMPACT

The Church of Rome fostered religious and cultural unity in Western Europe in the Medieval Period. By the end of the 5th century CE, Christian churches had been established in almost every village, town and city. The duties of the priests or the clergy were to preach and perform religious rites, and help the poor and the needy.

Priests had to live among the people. Some of the more **pious priests**, however, chose to live in remote, isolated places, far away from human habitation. They lived there as hermits and were known as monks. These monks became important members of medieval society, and the places where they lived came to be known as **monasteries**. Monks did not marry; they devoted their entire lives to **spiritual matters** and to the service of humanity. The women who followed the same path were known as **nuns**. They lived in separate monasteries known as **nunneries** or **convents**. The life of a nun was devoted to prayer and **service** of the poor, the sick and the oppressed. Nuns, too, could not marry.

Life in the monasteries was simple and **orderly**. Monks and nuns had to follow a very rigid **code of conduct**. A monastery was usually a **large, strong and simple building**, surrounded by gardens, orchards, fields and ponds. Inside the **abbey** was a small church, living quarters for the monks and nuns, a kitchen and storerooms. Attached to most monasteries were hospitals, schools and libraries.

Monasteries played a very important role in medieval Europe. The nuns **educated** children and **treated** the sick and the wounded. Very often, the barren land around the monastery was

brought under **cultivation** and made products. Architecture, mural painting, woodcarving and stained glass painting developed and flourished in the monasteries. The monasteries provided **shelter** for travellers and gave food and **clothing** to the poor and needy. They grew **medicinal herbs** in their gardens, which created a new interest in **botany**.

Critical Thinking

HOTS: Do you think the functions of monasteries and convents popularized Christianity among the people? Give reasons.

The greatest contribution of the monasteries was in the field of **education**. Some of the monasteries later developed into famous **secular** universities, such as the universities of Oxford and Cambridge. Besides religious texts, **secular subjects** such as history, philosophy, medicine, law and astrology were also taught in these universities.

The printing press and paper had not yet been invented, so the monks wrote books by hand on parchment. Most of the books were copies of the Bible and prayer books, and copies of Latin and Greek books on secular subjects. These books were a very useful **source** of knowledge of the ancient and medieval civilizations in Europe.

Think and Answer

Some Christian monasteries evolved into internationally renowned universities like the universities of Cambridge and Oxford. Which famous university in ancient India evolved from a Buddhist monastery? What similarities would you find in the subjects taught in these universities?

Critical Thinking

Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs)

Goal 4: Quality Education

Christian monasteries emerged as important centres of learning and education during the Medieval Period. Examine the contribution of Oxford and Cambridge universities to the promotion of quality education globally.

Know Your Sources

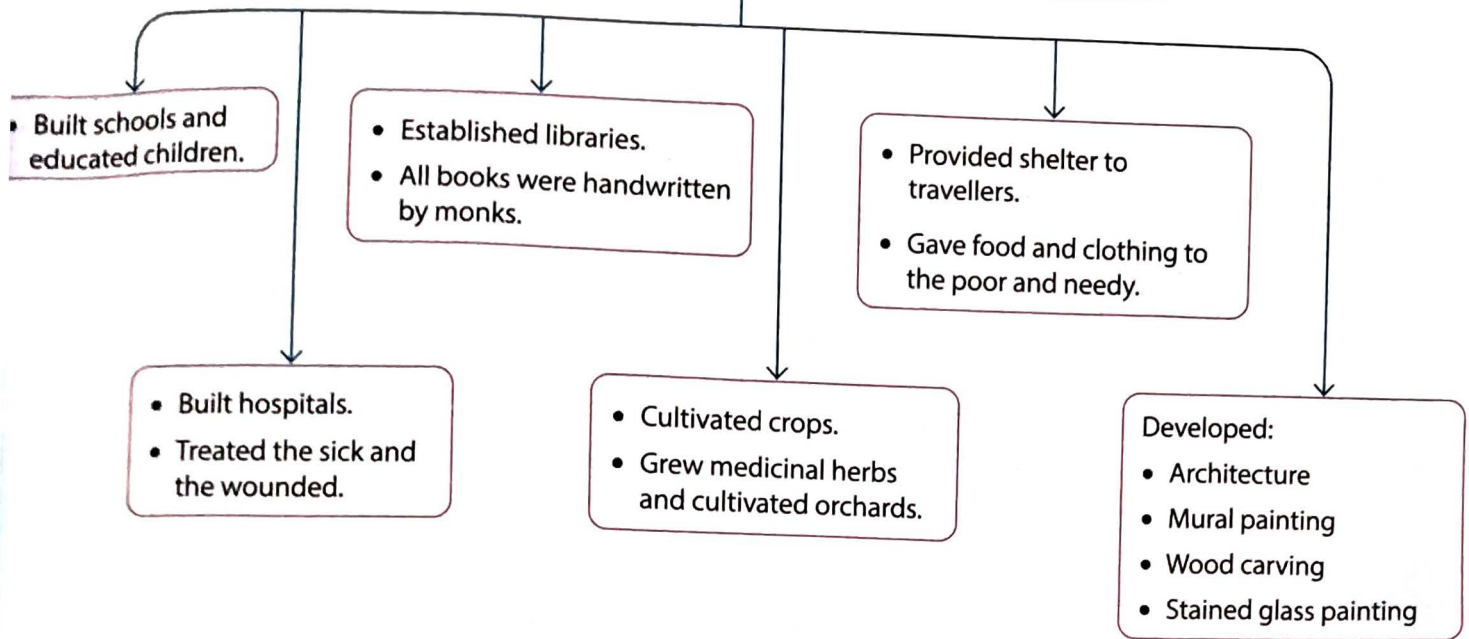


Murals in Bachkovo Monastery, Bulgaria, Europe—mural paintings flourished in the monasteries of medieval Europe.

- Why do you think the monks created these religious-themed murals?

C-12

ROLE OF CHRISTIAN MONASTERIES IN MEDIEVAL EUROPE

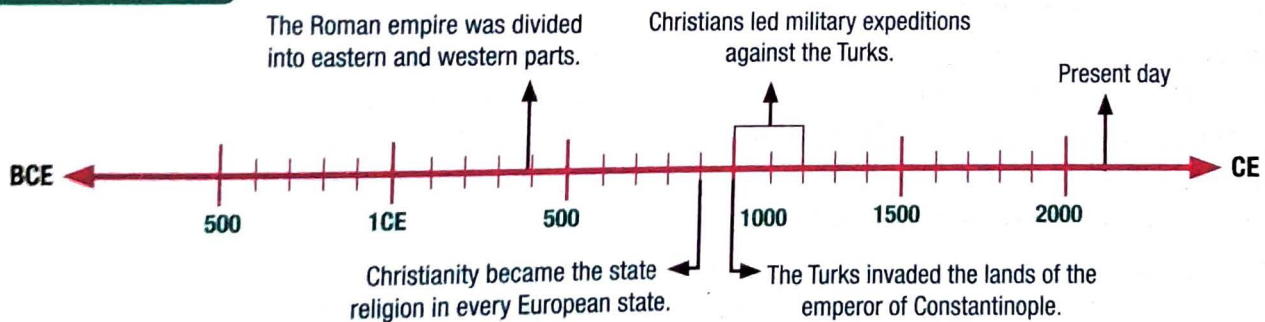


Values and Life Skills

Some people devote their entire lives to the service of humanity. We should be inspired by people who help the poor, the sick and the oppressed. We can also spend one or two hours in a week helping needy people.

- What are the ways in which you can help the poor and the needy in your neighbourhood? C-4.2

Timeline



Biography

Michelangelo was an Italian sculptor, painter, architect and poet of the Renaissance period. He is mostly known for painting the ceiling of the Sistine Chapel. It took him four years to complete the painting. The painting contains over 300 figures and shows nine episodes from the *Book of Genesis*.

